

Dvar Torah Outline — Rabbi Shulman on Nishmat/Yishtabach: 8 vs. 15 Praises, Hallel vs. Shirah, and the (Non-)Practice of the Fifth Cup

Abstract

Rabbi Shulman analyzes the closing structure of Hallel as it appears in Nishmat and Yishtabach, focusing on why some sections emphasize **eight** praises “from our side” while Yishtabach enumerates **fifteen** praises “from Hashem’s side.” He explains the conceptual difference between **הלל** (praise for Hashem’s beneficence) and **שירה** (song about Hashem’s might), and why the “big finish” of Hallel must culminate with a heightened form of praise. He then transitions to the sugya of a possible **fifth cup** at the seder, why it’s absent from the Mishnah’s required cups, and why הלל הגדול is called “great” as it highlights Hashem’s ongoing providence—especially sustaining all creation with food.

I. Entering the topic: 15 praises in “פרק ס”ה” (Yishtabach)

A. Rabbi Shulman’s opening framework

- Rabbi Shulman continues a text-based discussion in “פרק ס”ה,” which he says contains **שיר ושבחה**—fifteen forms of praise described as **ט”ו שבחים**.

B. The “15” motif in Torah and avodah

- Rabbi Shulman notes multiple appearances of **15** in Jewish sources and practice:
 - The **15 steps** between the עזרת נשים and the עזרה (as discussed in Sukkah), where the כהנים would stop and blow on certain steps.
 - **15 שיר המעלות**.
 - The Divine Name **י-ה**, which equals **15**, referenced through the phrase:
 - **“כִּי בְּיָהּ ה’ צוּר עוֹלָמִים”** (For with י-ה, Hashem formed worlds / is the Rock of worlds)

C. Listing the 15 praises

- Rabbi Shulman lists the well-known סדר of fifteen:
 - שיר ושבחה; הלל וזמרה; עוז וממשלה; נצח גדולה וגבורה; תהילה ותפארת; קדושה ומלכות; ברכות והודאות.
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II. Two categories of praise: what we do vs. what is “fitting” for Hashem (1:30)

A. The distinction Rabbi Shulman draws

- Rabbi Shulman explains there is a fundamental difference between:
 1. Praise described as actions of the **one praising**”... “יודו ויברכו וישבחו... (ישראל):
 2. Praise stated as inherently **appropriate for Hashem**”... “לך נאה” :

B. The “בת כהן” verse as a conceptual model

- Rabbi Shulman references the idea of a בת כהן who returns to her father’s household and can once again eat “from her father’s bread,” using it as an analogy for “returning” to a proper locus of entitlement/connection.

C. Applying it to liturgy: Nishmat vs. the end of Yishtabach

- Rabbi Shulman frames it as:
 - In **Nishmat** (and related phrasing), praise is stated **from our side**—what we can do.
 - In the closing of **Yishtabach**, we are not claiming capacity; rather we say: **to You, Hashem, it is fitting**—and then we invoke the elevated set of **15**.
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III. Why 8 praises from Israel, but 15 “from Hashem’s side”? (3:30)

A. “Eight” as the beauty Israel gives to Hashem

- Rabbi Shulman explains that the “eight praises” are characterized as:
 - “**הוא חלק של תפארת... מכח ישראל**” — a “beauty” Hashem “wears,” so to speak, generated by Israel’s praising.

- He supports this with the idea (as quoted in the shiur):
 - “את ה' האמרת” (you have exalted/beautified Hashem).

B. “Fifteen” as intrinsic praise of Hashem

- Rabbi Shulman explains that the **15 praises** are not about our performance but about Hashem **מצדו יתברך**—intrinsic divine attributes, hence:
 - “כי לך נאה”—to You it is fitting.

C. Question raised (and a proposed direction)

- A question is asked: what is the “root” symbolism of **15** (parallel to how 8 is often linked to “above nature”)?
- Rabbi Shulman proposes:
 - **15** corresponds to **י-ה**.
 - alludes to “**two worlds**” **צור עולמים**, and Rabbi Shulman suggests:
 - עולם הזה ↔ ה'
 - עולם הבא ↔ י'
 - Therefore, “15” may hint to praises that pertain beyond this-worldly human reach—touching the frame of both worlds.

IV. “Ending with a bang”: why the conclusion escalates praise (7:01)

A. The closing principle

- Rabbi Shulman explains a liturgical principle: one wants to finish with maximal praise.
 - In **Hallel**, the conclusion is “ברכת השיר.”

B. How the escalation works in practice

- Rabbi Shulman describes:
 - In a framework where **יהללך** is the concluding unit, you end with the “eight praises” that represent what we can say/do.
 - In **Nishmat**, since the “eight praises” already appear earlier, the conclusion must “step up”:
 - **Yishtabach** provides the “upgrade” by declaring that all **15** are fitting for Hashem—even beyond what we can fully claim to articulate.

V. Hallel vs. Shirah: praise for kindness vs. song for might (8:30)

A. Rabbi Shulman's definition

- Rabbi Shulman explains the conceptual difference:
 - **הלל**: praise for the **goodness and חסד** Hashem performed for us.
 - **שירה**: song about **גבורתו יתברך**—Hashem's might/majesty itself.

B. The conclusion of Hallel must include “shir”

- Rabbi Shulman notes that everyone agrees Hallel must culminate with a “song” dimension—hence “ברכת השיר.”

C. Connection to Shirat HaYam

- Rabbi Shulman states that whether one is speaking of **8** or **15** praises, both are **alluded to in Shirat HaYam**:
 - The “start” of song: “**אָז יָשִׁיר**” (“Then Moshe and the children of Israel sang...”)
 - He adds that the **ט”ו שבחים** of Yishtabach are darshened from Shirat HaYam (noting this is brought in Tur Orach Chaim).
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VI. Practical/nusach implication: the Maharal on saying both Y'hallelucha and Nishmat (11:30)

A. Rabbi Shulman presents the Maharal's critique

- Rabbi Shulman explains the Maharal argues it is difficult to justify saying **both**:
 - **יהללוך** and **נשמת**, especially if **יהללוך** is not given its proper **חתימה**.

B. The problem in common Haggadah printing/minhag

- Rabbi Shulman points out the issue (as the Maharal frames it):
 - If one recites **יהללוך** without a concluding **חתימה**, and then proceeds to other additions and concludes with **ישתבח**, then:
 - ,is no longer functioning as the intended climactic ending of Hallel **יהללוך**
 - and the “eight praises” are already present via Nishmat anyway—so its contribution is diminished.

VII. The fifth cup: sources, girsaot, and why the Mishnah omits it (13:30)

A. The Baraita statement and its two views

- Rabbi Shulman cites:
 - “כוס רביעי גומר עליו את ההלל, חמישי אומר עליו הלל הגדול דברי רבי טרפון, ויש אומרים השם רועי לא אחסר.”
- Core question Rabbi Shulman raises: **Is there really a fifth cup, and what is done with it?**

B. Rashbam's girsa vs. the other Rishonim (14:34)

- Rabbi Shulman explains:
 - Most מפרשים have a text that includes a **fifth cup**.
 - The רשב"ם does **not** have “כוס חמישי”; rather he has: on the **fourth cup** one completes הלל הגדול.

C. Reconciling the omission from the Mishnah

- Rabbi Shulman notes a strong question:
 - The Mishnah carefully enumerates the required cups—so why omit a fifth?
- He offers an answer:
 - The Mishnah mandates **no fewer than four** (absolute obligation),
 - but a fifth may be either:
 - מצוה מן המובחר (an ideal enhancement), or
 - רשות (optional religious act, akin to the category used for תפילת ערבית in the Gemara's terminology—though accepted later as obligatory).
- Practical upshot:
 - The fifth cup was never universally accepted as a חובה, and the מנהג is **not** to practice it.

D. Minhag described

- Rabbi Shulman states the practice:
 - “ואיננו נוהגים בכוס חמישי.”
 - “ואנו אומרים הלל הגדול אחר הלל ואחר כך נשמת...”
- Meaning: after Hallel, the community attaches הלל הגדול and then proceeds to the concluding “ברכת השיר” (Nishmat/Yishtabach structure as practiced).

VIII. Why “הלל הגדול” is called “great”: providence and universal sustenance (21:30)

A. The Gemara’s reason

- Rabbi Shulman quotes the Gemara’s explanation:
 - “ולמה נקרא הלל הגדול? שהקדוש ברוך הוא יושב ברומו של עולם ומחלק מזונות לכל בריה.”
- “Great” because it highlights Hashem providing sustenance to every creature.

B. 26 repetitions of “כי לעולם חסדו”

- Rabbi Shulman explains:
 - הלל הגדול contains כ”ו instances of “כי לעולם חסדו” (26 = the gematria of י-ה-ו-ה).

C. A conceptual claim: sustaining existence is “higher” than creation’s particulars (23:00)

- Rabbi Shulman explains the deeper idea:
 - Hashem is **קיום הנמצאים**—the One who sustains the existence of all beings.
 - Providing sustenance is described as a “עליון... יותר מן הבריאה” because:
 - Creation is “פרטי”—each being is created with distinct form,
 - while sustenance is “כללי”—a universal need shared by all living beings.

D. Universality of “food” as a unifying category

- Rabbi Shulman illustrates:
 - even what a dog can eat overlaps with גדול וקטן; is a shared concept across “מזון” what a person can eat.
 - Therefore, “מחלק מזון לכל בריה” is a particularly expansive, “great” expression of Hashem’s relationship to the world.
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IX. In Summary

- Rabbi Shulman distinguishes between praise **from Israel’s capacity** (eight) and praise stated as inherently **fitting for Hashem** (fifteen).
- He connects **15** to the Divine Name **י-ה** and suggests it may relate to praising Hashem across the framework of **two worlds**.

- Rabbi Shulman defines **הלל** as gratitude for Hashem's goodness and **שירה** as declaring Hashem's might, and explains why Hallel must conclude with an intensified "song" element.
- He presents the Maharal's challenge to combining יהללוך and נשמת in a way that undermines the proper חתימה of Hallel.
- He explains the fifth cup's status (optional/ideal but not obligatory), why the Mishnah omits it, and why the prevailing מנהג does not treat it as a required cup.
- He clarifies why הלל הגדול is "great": it emphasizes Hashem's universal providence—sustaining all existence through מזונות, a כלל shared by all creatures.